

Getting started and adding the colours

Step 1 Open a new template in the GIMP from *File* → *New*. Set the resolution that you want to work with. For this tutorial, we will use a resolution of 1920x1200 (16:10). It's good to create a large image, since we can then scale it down for lower resolution screens.

Step 2 With the background layer selected, grab the *Blend* tool. Set the foreground (FG) colour to `#a07c27`, and the background (BG) colour to `#be9a43`. Let the *Blend* tool remain at the default setting, and apply a linear gradient from top to bottom, in approximately the horizontal centre of the image. (Refer to Part 1 of Figure 1.)

Step 3 Create a new transparent layer, and set the name to *Colour2*. With the layer selected, make sure the *Blend* tool is still active. Set the FG colour to `#2675ad`, and the BG colour to `#11824d`. Apply a linear gradient from left to right, in approximately the vertical centre of the image, as indicated in Part 2 of Figure 1.

Step 4 Create another transparent layer, and name it *Colour3*. Set FG and BG colours to `#75050b` and `#af0f18`, respectively. Apply a slanting gradient as shown in Part 3 of Figure 1.

Step 5 To add a bit more spark to the wallpaper, we will add a radial gradient in the centre of the wallpaper. In a new transparent layer named *Colour4*, set the FG to *white* and BG to `#5b0005`. Change the *Blend* tool's shape to *Radial*. Apply a gradient from the centre of the image, then to the bottom right or bottom left corner, as shown in Part 4 of Figure 1.

In the *Layers* dialogue box, set the mode for the layers *Colour2*, *Colour3* and *Colour4* to *Overlay*. That gives the background a soothing copper-like effect. If you are not satisfied, feel free to experiment with the colour swatches.

The next thing to consider is toning the corners of the wallpaper. Though this is not of much concern, we will tone the wallpaper bright and dark at alternate/opposite corners.

Step 6 Create a new transparent layer, and name it *Glow*. Grab the *Blend* tool, with white (`#ffffff`) as the FG colour. Change the gradient shape back to *Linear* (if it is still set at *Radial*). Set the gradient style of FG to *Transparent*, and apply the gradient from the top left corner to a little way inside the wallpaper, as shown in Part 1 of Figure 2. To get a more subtle effect, start the gradient from some distance outside the image. Maximise the image window if it isn't maximised; if you are zoomed in too much, try zooming out to 33 or 25 per cent, so you can see the grey area outside the image itself. Estimate the centre of the image, trace an imaginary line from the centre to the upper left corner, and extend it outside the image area. From some point (on this imaginary line) outside the image area, start your gradient and drag inward, retracing your imaginary line through the upper left corner, till around the point where you see the lightening of colour (that is due to the

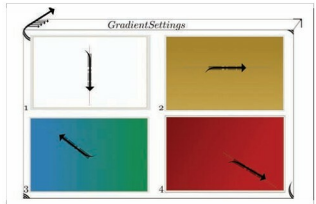


Figure 1: The basic gradients

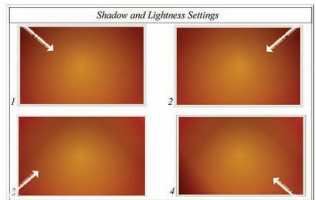


Figure 2: Shadow and lighting

radial gradient we added earlier).

Repeat this procedure for the top right corner as well, trying to begin the gradient about the same distance outside the image as you did for the left corner.

Step 7 On to the dark portion. Create a new transparent layer, named *Shadow*. Since shadows usually appear on the lower sides of an object, we will add the 'shadow' at the bottom corners of the wallpaper. The logic is the same as for the glow part—all we need to do is change the FG colour to black (`#000000`), then apply the gradient from a point beyond the bottom left corner, towards the centre of the image (till the point where the radial gradient lightens).

Repeat this step for the bottom right corner as well.

We are now done with the colouring and toning part. Next, we focus on getting shapes and styles with the *Paths* tool. Of course, we will be using the *blend/gradient* and *brush* tools for detailing and spicing up the wallpaper.

Shaping and styling with the paths tool

In order to create a path, we use the *paths* tool. As already discussed in earlier articles, since the *paths* tool offers more flexibility than other selection tools, we use it to draw our patterns and shapes. To create a path, simply follow the relevant steps:

- **Simple path:** A simple line, or a segment of it, is called a path. Since a line is a function of two points,